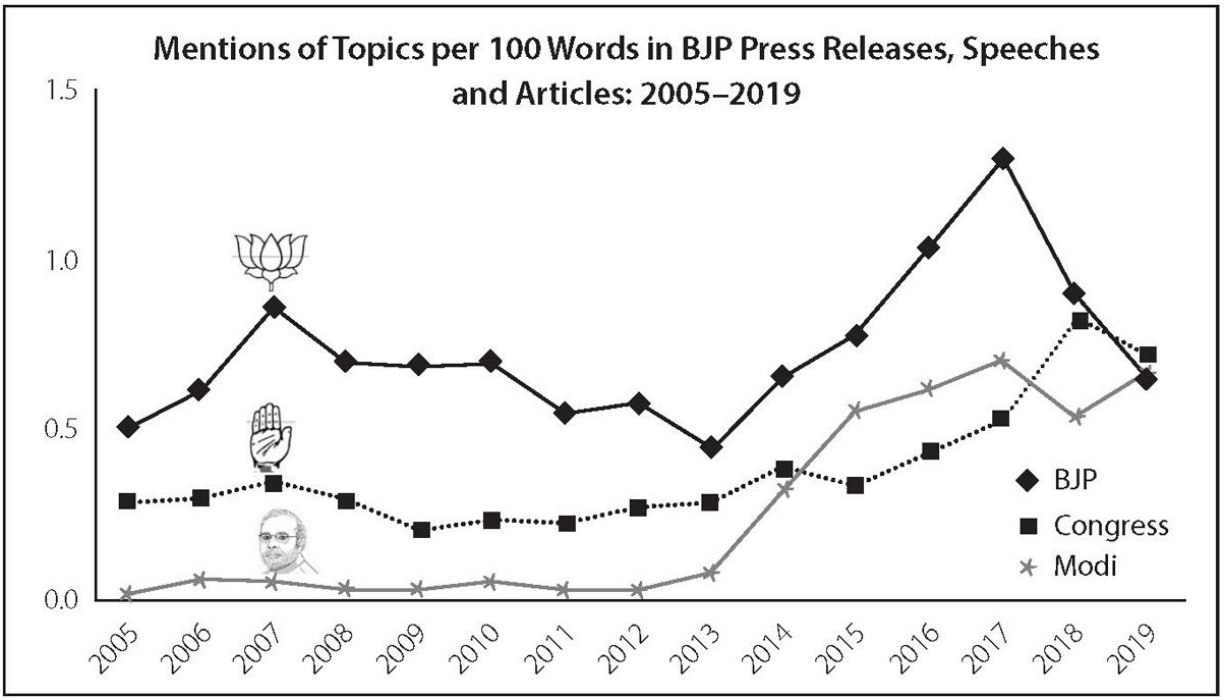
years were dominated by positive messaging by the party. The Narad Index shows that, in the first two years of the Modi government, the BJP focused much more on development, infrastructure and farmers in its messaging.

Figure 6.2: The BJP's Emphasis on the Congress is New, Increased Sharply After 2016



Source: Narad Index, Nalin Mehta and Rishabh Srivastava; for more details see Appendix 4/online on nalinmehta.in

This big political communication shift first began in 2016 when we started seeing a dramatic upswing in Congress-related talk by the BJP. Over the next three years, the BJP steadily ramped up the volume of its anti-Congress talk—and by the 2019 general election, this talk had overtaken its communication on all other issues.

Why did the BJP make this shift? The answer lies in a 2018 blog by then Union finance minister, the late Arun Jaitley, who asked whether the Congress was becoming 'ideologyless', and if what he called 'anti-Modism' was its only ideology. Paradoxically, that was the year when the BJP spoke more about the Congress than it did in the fourteen years (2005–2019) we tracked. Referring to Rahul Gandhi's